

POST INDEPENDENCE DEVELOPMENTS

IDENTITY POLITICS - 2 MODULE-15



COMMUNALISM IN SECULAR DEMOCRACY

- 1** Rise of politics based on religious identity –
Bhartiya Jana Sangh merged into Janata Party,
finally into the Bhartiya Janata Party (BJP) in 1980.
- 2** BJP adopted a broader political platform –
embraced Gandhian Socialism as its ideology, but
later emphasized the Hindu nationalism through
'Hindutva'. Hindutva, as defined by VD Savarkar
means 'Hinduness'.
- 3** Belonging to the Indian nation meant accepting
India as their 'fatherland' (pitrubhu) and their 'holy
land' (punyabhu). They believed a strong nation can
be built on the basis of a strong and united national
culture. In India, this culture was of the Hindu
culture.



VD SAVARKAR

RASHTRIYA SWAYAMSEVAK SANGH

- 1** Once limited to northern India, it setup active branches in states where it previously had no presence at all. Everywhere the core ideology of the Sangh was adapted to the local context.
- 2** Thus, in Gujarat, the rebuilding of the ancient Somnath temple was celebrated as a manifestation of a united and assertive Hinduism.
- 3** In Orissa the focus was on the great Jagannatha temple, used by the RSS to build bridges between the local and pan-Indian Hindu identities.
- 4** There was a particular emphasis on work in tribal areas, on 'reclaiming' the adivasis and 'returning' them to the Hindu fold.
- 5** Schools were opened where tribal youths were taught Sanskrit and acquainted with Hindu myths and legends.
- 6** The RSS worked hard in times of natural calamity, bringing grains when the rains failed and rebuilding homes after an earthquake.



SOMNATH TEMPLE



JAGANNATHA TEMPLE

RELIGION BASED POLITICS

- 1 The Hindus were divided within themselves – by caste, sect, language and region.
- 2 From the time it was founded in 1925, the mission of the RSS had been to make the Hindus a strong and cohesive fighting force.
- 3 For its members, as for the organization as a whole, religious sentiment went hand-in-hand with political ambition.
- 4 In the 1980s, the campaign to build a temple where a mosque stood in Ayodhya generated a widespread appeal.
- 5 Many Hindus across India, of different castes, were beginning to see this as a 'point of honour in our national life'.
- 6 The BJP supported V. P. Singh's National Front without joining the government. However, the decision to implement the Mandal Commission's report, announced in August 1990, threw the party into a tizzy.



UTTARAKHAND

HARYANA

DELHI

UTTAR PRADESH

N E P A L

RAJASTHAN

AYODHYA

BIHAR

JHARKHAND

MADHYA PRADESH

CHHATTISGARH

RATH YATRA

- 1** Rather than take a position, the BJP chose to shift the terms of political debate, away from Mandal and caste and back towards religion and the mandir/mosque question.
- 2** The party announced a yatra, or march, from the ancient temple of Somnath in Gujarat to the town of Ayodhya.
- 3** The march was led by L. K. Advani, Commencing on 25 September 1990, Advani's Rath Yatra planned to reach Ayodhya five weeks later, after travelling more than 6,000 miles through eight states.
- 4** The march's imagery was religious, allusive, militant, masculine, and anti-Muslim. This was reinforced by the speeches made by Advani, which accused the government of 'appeasing' the Muslim minority and of practising a 'pseudo-secularism' which denied the legitimate interests and aspirations of the Hindu majority.



TEMPLE AT AYODHYA

1 Babri Masjid issue: Babri Masjid was a 16th century mosque built by Mir Baqi , Babur's General in Ayodhya. There was a belief amongst many that it was built after demolishing the Ram Temple, where Lord Ram was born.

2 The Faizabad district court in 1986 ordered unlocking of Babri Masjid premises for Hindus to offer prayers as they considered the site to be a temple.

3 When the doors were opened, Hindu and Muslim organisations mobilized their communities leading to communal tensions.

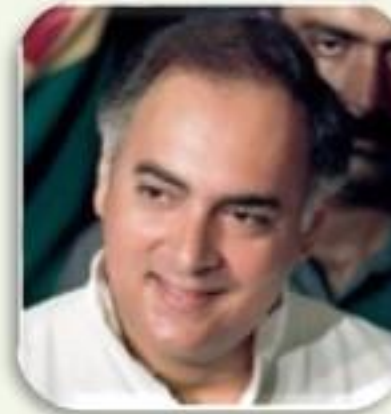
4 BJP made it a major electoral and political issue and organized the 'Rathiyatra' from Somnath in Gujrat to Ayodhya in UP.



MIS-CALCULATIONS OF RAJIV GANDHI

- 1** In 1985, the supreme court of India ruled in favour of Shah Bano, an elderly divorced Muslim woman seeking monthly maintenance from her remarried husband.
- 2** She was opposing the provisions of India's Muslim personal law, evoking the indignation of conservative Muslims.
- 3** In order to satisfy to this segment of Muslims, Ravij Gandhi announced that it would bring in legislation to effectively nullify the supreme court's Shah Bano judgement.

Rajiv tried to restore the balance by giving the Hindus something as well!



RAJIV GANDHI



SHAH BANO BEGUM

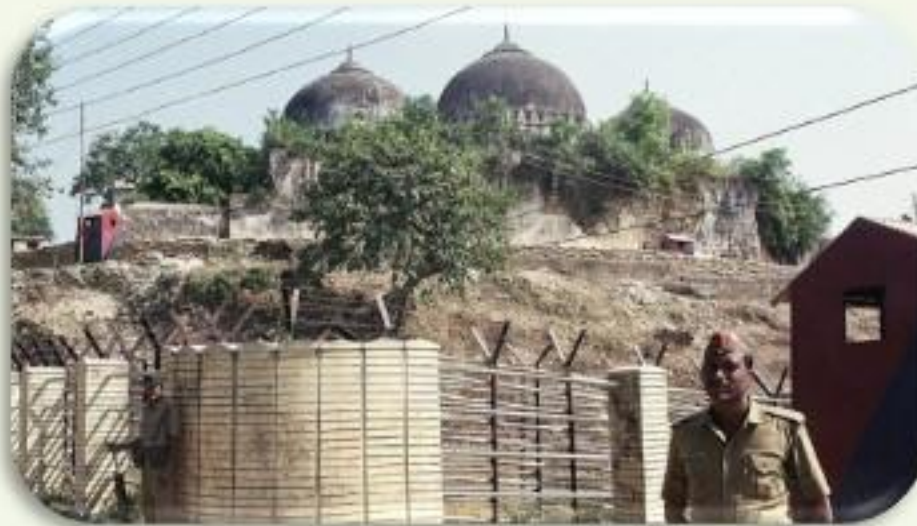
RAJIV GANDHI ON BABRI MASJID

1 In 1986, PM Rajiv Gandhi ordered the locks on the Ramjanmabhoomi-Babri Masjid in Ayodhya removed.

2 Earlier, a priest had been permitted to perform puja once a year for the idols installed there in 1949.

3 His decision meant all Hindus were given access to what they consider the birthplace of Rama.

4 Architecturally, the building was and remained a mosque while functionally, it had been and continued to be a Hindu temple.



RAJIV GANDHI ON BABRI MASJID

5 Rajiv's decision in 1986 was important because it allowed for only one interpretation: he favored the Hindu claim.

6 This seemed logical, for the site has a sacred significance for Hindus as the birthplace of Rama, while it had no special status for Muslims.

7 Historical documents confirmed that Hindus continued to go on pilgrimage to the site all through the centuries of Muslim occupation, while hardly any Muslim went on pilgrimage there.

8 In 1989, The Rajiv Gandhi government allowed Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) to perform puja near the disputed site.



TEMPLE AT AYODHYA

- 5 The building of a Ram temple in Ayodhya was presented as the symbolic fulfilment of these interests and aspirations.
- 6 Some kar sevaks managed to reach the mosque.
- 7 One planted a saffron flag on the structure; others attacked it with axes and hammers. To stop a mass invasion the BSF jawans used tear gas and, later, live bullets.



ELECTIONS OF 1991

- 1 Among the casualties of the rath yatra was Prime Minister V. P. Singh. In November 1990 he resigned, unable to sustain his minority government in the absence of BJP support. As in 1979 – when Morarji Desai demitted office – the Congress allowed a lame-duck Prime Minister.
- 2 Elections were held in 1991. Rajiv Gandhi passed away during the campaign and this sympathy generated 244 seats for Congress.
- 3 With support from independents, they were in a position to form a government.
- 4 P. V. Narasimha Rao, a veteran of the Congress Party from Andhra Pradesh who had held important positions in Rajiv Gandhi's Cabinet, was sworn in as Prime Minister. BJP won 120 seats.



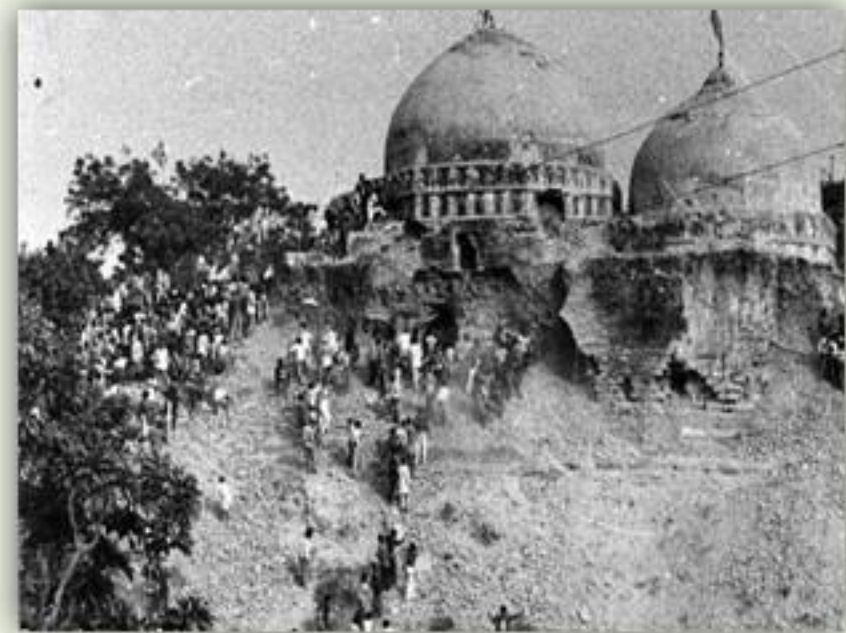
GOVERNMENT RESPONSE

- 1 In July 1992, a team from the central government was sent to study the situation. the Uttar Pradesh government, headed by Kalyan Singh, had turned a blind eye to these activities. There had been, in sum, 'flagrant violation of the law in Ayodhya'.
- 2 He had several meetings with VHP leaders and also consulted with the opposing Babri Masjid Action Committee.
- 3 Meanwhile, the VHP announced that 6 December had been chosen as the 'auspicious' day on which work on the temple would commence.
- 4 The Chief Minister, Kalyan Singh, was summoned to New Delhi. Narasimha Rao urged him to allow the Supreme Court to decide on the case.



HINDU FUNDAMENTALISM

- 1 About 20,000 paramilitary troops were sent to Ayodhya for the preparation for 6 December 1992.
- 2 On the other side, more than 100,000 kar sevaks had reached the temple town, 'complete with trishuls [tridents] and bows and arrows'.
- 3 By noon, volunteers were crawling all over the Masjid, holding saffron flags and shouting slogans of victory.
- 4 By evening, all the domes were broken and the entire structure was demolished.
- 5 Only after the deed was done was action taken – in the shape of the dismissal of the Uttar Pradesh government and the imposition of President's Rule.



HINDU-MUSLIM RIOTS

- 1 The communal sentiment strengthened and the kar sevaks destroyed homes of Muslims.
- 2 In other towns, riots were a consequence of processions organized by the Vishwa Hindu Parishad.
- 3 Elsewhere it was Muslims who came out into the streets to protest the demolition, by attacking police posts and attempting to burn government buildings.
- 4 On 9 December the Shiv Sena and the BJP announced a city wide strike to protest against the arrest of their leaders in Ayodhya. Mosques and Muslim establishments were attacked.
- 5 Curfew was imposed, and the army called in. It still took ten days for the city to get back to normal.



KASHMIRI PANDITS

- 1 The Muslims in India were poorer than the Hindus, as well as less educated.
- 2 The rise of Hindu fundamentalism in the 1990s put an already vulnerable minority further on the defensive.
- 3 In the border state of Jammu and Kashmir, however, the roles were reversed.
- 4 Here, the Muslim majority was increasingly expressing its aspirations in religious terms, with the Hindu minority suffering as a consequence.
- 5 The popular revolt that broke out in the Valley in 1989 was at first led by the Jammu and Kashmir Liberation Front. The cry of azadi (freedom) was being replaced by the call of jihad (holy war).



COMMUNAL HATRED

- 1 One consequence of this turn to religion was that the community of Kashmiri Pandits became suspect in the eyes of the militants.
- 2 They were Hindus, but in other respects akin to their Muslim brethren, speaking the same language, eating the same kind of food, partaking of the same syncretic culture of the Valley.
- 3 In the past there had been economic rivalry between Hindus and Muslims. Pandit's control over cultivable land and state administration was ended.
- 4 In panic, Pandit families began leaving the Valley for the Hindu-majority Jammu region. Others fled further afield, to Delhi and even to Bombay.
- 5 There were an estimated 200,000 Pandits living in the Kashmir Valley. By the summer of 1990, at least half had left. They lived in refugee camps, some run by the government, others by the RSS.

COVERT ACTIVITIES OF ISI

- 1 Throughout the 1990s there were further attacks on Pandits who had chosen to remain. Sometimes entire hamlets were set on fire.
- 2 By the end of the decade, fewer than 4,000 Pandits were left in the Valley.
- 3 The growing militancy in Kashmir was actively aided by Pakistan. That country's Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) ran camps where terrorists were trained in the use of arms and provided maps of the region.

- 4 For the Jihadis, India was the land of the kafirs, or unbelievers. There were killings of activists from the National Conference, which wanted autonomy within India, of the JKLF, which wanted independence rather than merger with Pakistan, and of the People's Conference, which advocated non-violence.



GODHRA RIOTS

- 1** Meanwhile the Vishwa Hindu Parishad organized tours of Ayodhya by kar sevaks from all over the country.
- 2** They also held religious ceremonies in anticipation of the building of the temple.
- 3** One such yagna, held in the last week of February 2002, was attended by hundreds of volunteers from the state of Gujarat. On their way back home, many of them boarded the Sabarmati Express.
- 4** Sabarmati Express, travelling from Muzaffarpur to Ahmedabad had arrived at Godhra station on 27 February, 2002.
- 5** This train supposedly contained about 2,000 kar sevaks who had attended the Purnahuti Maha Yagna, as a part of the Ram Temple building programme and had boarded the train from Ayodhya.
- 6** As soon as the train reached Godhra, a coach of the Sabarmati Express was set on fire. About 60 people died and several others were injured because of the fire.



GODHRA RIOTS

- 1** The train burning incident had within hours triggered violent riots across the state.
- 2** The riots broke out on the evening of February 27 and continued for 2-3 months across the state.
- 3** The Centre in 2005 informed Rajya Sabha that the riots claimed the lives of 254 Hindus and 790 Muslims. Tens of thousands were rendered homeless as well.
- 4** The rise of the Hindu right in general, and the events at Ayodhya in particular, prompted a fresh wave of gloomy forebodings about the future of India.
- 5** The National Human Rights Commission criticized the Gujarat government's role in failing to control violence and help the victims.
- 6** Election Commission ordered assembly elections to be postponed. It exposed the danger to democratic politics when religious sentiments are used for political purposes.

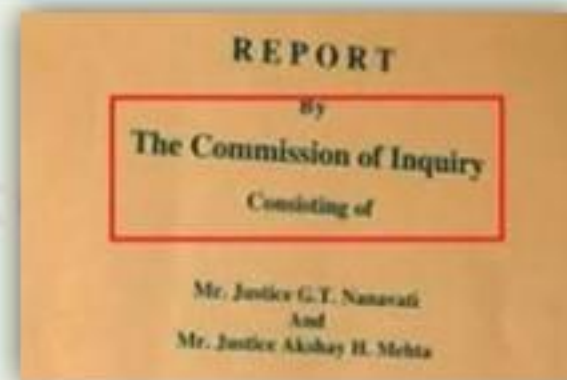


GOVERNMENT RESPONSE

1 The Congress-led UPA government set up a separate inquiry commission headed by Justice UC Banerjee, who in his report submitted in March 2006, called the incident to be an accident. The Supreme Court rejected the report as unconstitutional and invalid.

2 Afterwards, the Supreme Court constituted a Special Investigation Team. Justice KG Shah died in March 2008 before the commission could complete its inquiry. His position was taken over by Justice Akshay H Mehta.

3 Justice Nanavati and Justice Akshay Mehta submitted the final report of the Nanavati-Shah Commission that same year describing the train burning as a conspiracy.



GOVERNMENT RESPONSE

- 1 Trials in the case started over eight years after the incident on June 1, 2009.
- 2 A special SIT court convicted 31 people on March 1, 2011, out of whom 11 were awarded death sentences and 20 life imprisonment. A special SIT court convicted 31 people on March 1, 2011, out of whom 11 were awarded death sentences and 20 life imprisonment.
- 3 The SIT court concurred with the charges of the prosecution that this was not an incident of unplanned mob outrage and rather it involved conspiracy.
- 4 The 31 convicts were convicted under the Indian Penal Code sections related to criminal conspiracy, murder and attempt to murder.
- 5 The Gujarat government later raised questions on the acquittals, a series of appeals were filed in the Gujarat High Court challenging the convictions.
- 6 The 63 people acquitted also include the prime accused in the case Maulana Umarji, Mohammad Hussain Kalota, Mohammad Ansari and Nanumiya Chaudhary.

GOVERNMENT RESPONSE

- 1** A Commission of Inquiry was constituted by the Gujarat government headed by then Chief Minister Narendra Modi.
- 2** The Commission consisted Justice G T Nanavati and Justice KG Shah. The Commission in its report submitted that most of the 59 people killed were kar sevaks who were returning from Ayodhya in Uttar Pradesh.
- 3** Fifty-nine kar sevaks were killed after a coach of the Sabarmati Express was set ablaze in February 2002, triggering one of the worst communal riots witnessed in the country.



NARENDRA MODI
CM, GUJARAT – (2001-2014)



WE EXPRESS OUR
SINCERE THANKS
FOR VIEWING THIS VIDEO

Presented by



Learning Space

For Suggestions:

suggestions@learningspace.in

To Contact us:

info@learningspace.in

For Information:

info.learningspacedigital@gmail.com

Visit us at:

www.learningspacedigital.com

0866 244 44 72

98499 42299

94415 27588